CHANGING CHALLENGING BEHAVIORS

Our approach:

Teach them what to do instead of the negative behavior
Clarifies expectations and helps them know how to get our positive attention

Start with what they're capable of doing now
Goal is to "set them up for success"

Catch them being good
Use the power of your positive attention to increase good behaviors

Prompt them to do the good behavior as needed
Helps them remember to do the new behavior

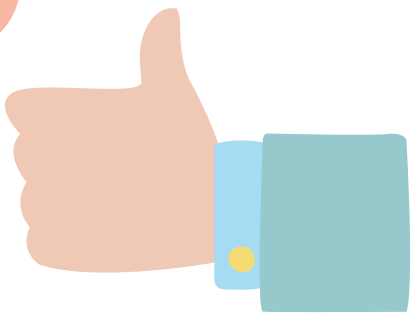
Create a habit for yourself
Help yourself remember to prompt and praise them

Strengthen their capabilities over time
Slowly increase expectations to grow their abilities

Combine multiple approaches if needed
Consider using incentives or other strategies to "boost" progress







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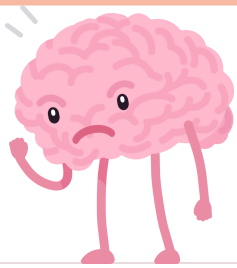
YOUNG CHILD PARENTING GROUP AT MGH

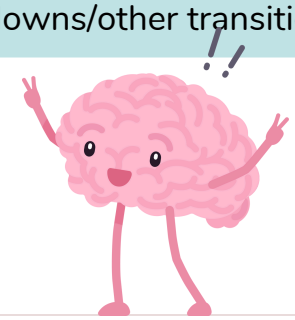
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CHANGING CHALLENGING BEHAVIORS

How to "teach them what to do instead"

Challenging Behavior:	What to do instead:
Grabbing a toy from their friend	Asking for a turn, playing with another toy instead
Yelling	Using indoor voice/kind words
Refusing to leave the park	**Leaving the park calmly when you ask** (works best in combination with timers/countdowns/other transition strategies)
Annoying their sibling/you	Playing quietly by themselves, asking you directly for quality time
Whining/repeating	Using a "big kid" voice, asking once and listening to the answer
Refusing to transition to bedtime routine	**Calmly transitioning to bedtime when you ask** (works best in combination with timers/countdowns/other transition strategies)





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CHANGING CHALLENGING BEHAVIORS

IGNORE NEGATIVE BEHAVIORS WHENEVER POSSIBLE

As long as the behavior isn't unsafe, **ignoring will decrease the chance that it will occur again**

- The behavior will likely get worse the first few times you ignore it -- hang in there and it eventually will go away

Example: Demanding a candy bar in the checkout line



- If you give in and buy them the candy bar, they'll learn that it works and will do it more frequently!
- If you ignore the demands, they'll learn that it doesn't work and eventually stop asking for a candy bar every time you're at the store



USE TIME-OUTS WHEN NEEDED

Use time-outs for unsafe behaviors that can't be ignored

- Hitting, kicking, breaking things

<u>The purpose of time-out is not to get attention from you for unsafe behaviors and calm down</u>

- Tell kids in advance which behaviors will lead to time out and what the procedure will be (e.g., where they sit)
- Ignore them during time-out
- Keep it short (1 minute per year old is a helpful rule of thumb)

Time-outs work best in combination with positive parenting strategies

- Like punishment, time-outs don't teach kids what to do
- Instead, use time-outs when kids behave in unsafe ways in combination with promoting and praising them for the positive opposite (e.g., behaving safely)

If you have to use time-outs many times a day, other strategies will be needed

- Does your child have the skills to behave the way you are expecting?
- Are there more positive ways that they can easily get your attention?





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